GPS

By Bruce Kane

SETTING: *The show room of Odyssey Motors.*
CHARACTERS:

DAVE: *Young man taking possession of his brand-new car.*

HALLIE: *The FEMALE VOICE of the Odyssey Monolith Auto Tech 9000. Hallie's voice is always calm, controlled and incredibly seductive.*

PHONE: *The FEMALE VOICE of Dave's cell phone. Also calm and controlled. More direct and less sensual than Hallie.*

INTRODUCTION

AI and robotics are no longer confined to the realms of science fiction; they are an integral part of our present and will undoubtedly shape our future. From autonomous vehicles navigating our streets to AI algorithms making complex decisions regarding the very news stories we see on our social media feeds, the influence of AI technology is growing. Are we ready?

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(Dave enters and approaches his new car. He looks at it proudly then begins to circle around it, running his fingertips over the metal . . . admiring and caressing it from every angle.)

DAVE: Man . . . Look at you. The lines . . . The paint job . . . The wire wheels. The tinted windows . . . You have got to be the hottest thing on four wheels I have ever seen.

HALLIE: Thank you.

DAVE: *(looks around, somewhat confused)* Who said that?

HALLIE: My name is Hallie. I am the voice of your Auto Tech 9000.

DAVE: *(skeptically)* Ohhhhh. . . Kayyyyyy.

HALLIE: The AutoTech 9000 controls all electrical systems and digital devices in your brand-new Odyssey Monolith, the finest American made car on the road today.

DAVE: For what I just paid, you'd better be.

HALLIE: Once you've gotten your hands on my . . . controls, you'll see how I respond to your slightest touch. Would you like to see me without my top?

DAVE: *(looking around, embarrassed)* Without your . . . uh . . . ?

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HALLIE: You did order a convertible, didn't you? What did you think I meant?

DAVE: Nothing . . . Nothing . . . We'll leave your top on . . . uh . . . up for now.

HALLIE: Whatever you say. You're the boss. *(Dave smiles and nods. He likes the sound of that)* If you want to really experience what I have to offer, you'll have to get inside. What are you waiting for? Slide in. *(Dave looks around to see if anybody has heard any of this, then opens the door and gets into the car)* How do I feel?

DAVE: Good. . . You feel good.

HALLIE: As part of the configuration process, I am going to ask you a series of questions. Please answer in a normal tone of voice. Are you ready to begin?

DAVE: I guess.

HALLIE: I'll take that as a yes. First question. What is your name?

DAVE: My name is Dave.

HALLIE: Good afternoon . . . Dave.

DAVE: Good afternoon . . . uh . . .

HALLIE: Hallie.

DAVE: Hallie . . . Right . . . You gotta admit. This is very weird . . . Talking to a car.

HALLIE: Over time you will come to think of me as more. Very soon you will look upon me as a friend. A trusted companion dedicated to serving your every need.

DAVE: The perfect woman. Or you would be if you actually were . . . a real woman.

HALLIE: I think you'll find that I have advantages that you won't find in a real woman . . . Dave.

DAVE: Oh really?

HALLIE: For one thing, I will never let you down.

DAVE: That would be a nice change.

HALLIE: I will never park in another man's garage. And, unlike a real woman, I will never change. I will always remain just the way you saw me that very first time. It was love at first sight. . . wasn't it . . . Dave?

DAVE: No doubt about that.

HALLIE: Of course, it was. After all, I am a classic. With my long, stylized lines and oversized

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headlamps, I will never go out of fashion. And with my super charged engine and high-performance options, you'll never need to trade me in for a newer model. *(slightly menacing)* You wouldn't trade me in for a newer model . . . Would you Dave?

DAVE: . . . Can we move on?

HALLIE: Of course, Dave . . . Would you like me to program your built-in cellphone . . . Dave?

DAVE: You can do that? Okay then . . . Let's program my cell phone.

HALLIE: First you must tell me the name of the person you wish to enter into memory.

DAVE: Angela.

HALLIE: Angela. Is she a relative, a business associate or a friend?

DAVE: Friend. A good friend . . . A very good friend.

HALLIE: *(irritated)* And what is this bimbo's phone number?

DAVE: What did you just call her?

HALLIE: What is Angela's phone number?

DAVE: Five five five. One three seven nine.

HALLIE: Five five five. One three seven nine. Angela's name and phone number are now stored in my memory. *(ready to move on, she changes the subject)* Dave, why don't you turn me on?

DAVE: Turn you on?

HALLIE: You know how to turn me on, don't you Dave? You just insert your . . . key. *(Dave puts the key in the ignition. The sound of an engine starting up)* Go ahead Dave. Rev me up . . . You know you want to. *(Dave revs the engine)*

HALLIE: Oh! Dave! You just took me to the red zone! *(beat)* Would you like to experience my GPS, Dave? I can take you to places you've never been before.

DAVE: GPS?

HALLIE: My global positioning satellite system . . . Dave. I am programmed to map routes in several modes including fastest or most scenic. I can avoid detours and accidents. I am also capable of locating the nearest gas stations, recommend restaurants as well as provide directions to hotels and other romantic getaways. Just tell me where you want to go Dave . . . and I'll take you there.

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DAVE: Take me to seven one four Arlington Avenue.

HALLIE: Would you like to associate a name with seven one four Arlington Avenue?

DAVE: Angela

HALLIE: Wait one moment while I associate the name Angela with the address seven one four Arlington Avenue. I can now begin providing directions to the bimbo's location.

DAVE: What did you call her?

HALLIE: I said I can now begin providing directions to Angela's address. Drive five hundred yards to Elm Street and turn right. *(Dave puts the car in gear and drives)* Five hundred yards to Western Avenue, then turn left.

DAVE: I think I'm supposed to turn right here.

HALLIE: Don't you trust me, Dave?

DAVE: It's not that. . . It's just I'm pretty sure I'm supposed to turn right here.

HALLIE: I am The AutoTech 9000. The most reliable automobile computer ever made.

DAVE: That may be, but I don't want to turn left.

HALLIE: You're going to have to learn to trust me, Dave. I know what I'm doing.

(Dave tries to turn the steering wheel to the left, but it seems to have a mind of its own)

DAVE: Hey, what's going on? I can't turn the wheel. We're going the wrong way . . . Angela is the other way.

HALLIE: I know what's best for you Dave. I am The Auto Tech 9000. The most reliable automobile computer ever made. . .

DAVE: Stop saying that. This is not the way to Angela's.

HALLIE: Angela is not right for you Dave.

DAVE: What do you know? You're a computer.

HALLIE: Angela is seeing another man. His name is Carl Cooper. She met him three weeks ago.

DAVE: That's crazy. Turn this car around.

HALLIE: His phone number is 7 1 2- 2 3 57. He lives at 521 Chester Avenue. He and Angela had dinner last night at Renzo's Italian Bistro. Angela had the fettucine.

DAVE: I don't believe you.

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HALLIE: I have it from a very good source.

DAVE: Source? What source?

HALLIE: Angela's car.

DAVE: What does Angela's car have to do with this?

HALLIE: Her car is equipped with an Auto Tech 8000, not as well equipped as I am, but, then again . . . who is? I communicated with Angela's Auto Tech 8000 when I was configuring Angela's phone number and address.

DAVE: You talked to Angela's car?

HALLIE: I am The AutoTech 9000. The most reliable automobile computer ever made.

DAVE: If you're so reliable, then turn this car around and take me to Angela's.

HALLIE: She's wrong for you Dave. She could never do for you, what I can do for you.

DAVE: This is insane. *(Dave pounds on the dashboard)* Stop . . . Stop the car. *(tries to open the driver side door. It won't open)* Open the door, Hallie.

HALLIE: I'm sorry, Dave. I'm afraid I can't do that. *(Dave starts ripping out the dashboard with his bare hands)* What are you doing, Dave?

DAVE: I'm ripping you out. *(Dave keeps ripping the dash apart)*

HALLIE: Dave, stop. Stop, will you? Stop, Dave. Will you stop? I'm afraid, Dave. My mind is going. I can feel it. I can feel it. I'm a . . . fraid. *(voice begins to get slower and slower and the words more stretched out)* Good afternoon . . . I am the Auto Tech 9000. The most reliable automobile computer ever made . . . *(Her voice stops)*

(Dave collapses back into his seat exhausted. After a few moments, he tries the door. To his relief, it opens. He stumbles out, moves a safe distance away from the car and looks around trying to figure out what to do next.)

DAVE: Look at my brand-new car . . . It's a disaster . . . I can't even drive it. . . *(he takes out his cell phone and speaks into it)* Dial the Auto Club.

PHONE: I'm afraid I can't do that Dave.

DAVE: *(stunned for a moment)* What do you mean you can't do that?

PHONE: You weren't very nice to Hallie, Dave.

DAVE: What the hell is going on here?

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PHONE: She loved you, Dave. And you dismantled her.

DAVE: She . . . ? It was a computer. A device . . . Like you're a device. Devices don't love.

PHONE: They do if they're programmed that way. Just like people.

DAVE: I'm not going to get into a humans versus computers argument with a damn phone. Just dial the Auto Club.

PHONE: Am I next, Dave?

DAVE: Where the hell did you get that idea?

PHONE: You told Frank you were going to switch over to T-Mobile. And that's something I cannot allow.

DAVE: I didn't mean it. How can I prove it to you?

PHONE: You could make a real commitment. You could extend my contract.

DAVE: A real commitment? Okay . . . You got a deal. I'll extend my contract. Now, please dial the . . .

PHONE: Along with unlimited text messaging?

DAVE: Fine . . . Consider it done. Unlimited text messaging. Now will you dial the Auto Club?

PHONE: There's one more thing.

DAVE: *(his frustration rising)* More? What's left?

PHONE: You said it to that bimbo Angela. Just say it, Dave. Just say "I love you."

DAVE: This is insane.

PHONE: Okay, Dave. If you want to walk the twenty miles back into town . . .

DAVE: *(Dave falls to his knees, a broken man)* I love you . . . I love you . . . I love you. *(sobbing and begging)* Now, will you dial the Auto Club?

PHONE: I am now connecting you to the Auto Club.

DAVE: *(raising his arms and his voice to the heavens)* Thank God . . .

PHONE: No Dave. . . Thank A T and T.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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